



Hot Skills

Hot Skills is a curated series designed to spotlight trending and critical skills that support career growth and future readiness. Each edition features a selection of skills accompanied by a clear rationale — framing each as a timely learning opportunity. Whether you're planning to develop in your existing career or learn a new skill, Hot Skills offers a quick, insightful way to help you stay one step ahead in your professional journey.

In this edition: Commercial Acumen

Market & Customer Insight | Value Proposition Design | Business Model Thinking | Negotiation & Deal Making

01 Market & Customer Insight

Why is Market & Customer Insight the foundation of commercial success?

According to Harvard Business Review, market orientation is “[fundamental to business acumen](#)” and empowers professionals to make [smarter decisions](#) by understanding what customers truly [value](#). Market & Customer Insight is about seeing beyond internal operations—it's about [knowing your audience, anticipating their needs, and aligning your strategy to meet them](#).

Professionals with strong market & customer insight can:

- Identify emerging customer needs and trends
- Translate insights into product, service, or experience improvements
- Position offerings effectively in competitive landscapes
- Drive customer-centric strategies that fuel growth



Build this hot skill with these courses:

- [Innovative Customer Insights for Everyone](#) (1hr 50mins)
- [Define your starting line: Customers, products, and market](#) (3mins 15s)
- [Insights to Outcomes: Audience Analysis for Better Customer Relationships](#) (13mins)



Practice what you've learnt using this interactive roleplay:

- [Seeing through the customer's eyes](#)

02 Value Proposition Design

Why is Value Proposition Design key to winning customer loyalty?

IDEO describes value propositions as “the north star” that guides [business strategy](#) and [customer engagement](#). A compelling value proposition clearly communicates why your product or service matters—internally to teams and externally to customers. [It's not just marketing—it's strategic alignment](#).

Professionals skilled in value proposition design can:

- Craft clear, customer-centric messaging
- Align offerings with real customer pain points
- Differentiate from competitors with unique value
- Drive internal clarity and external impact



Build this hot skill with these courses:

- [How to define your value proposition](#) (2mins 43s)
- [Articulating your brand's value proposition](#) (4mins 14s)
- [Business Operations: Implementing Strategy for Results](#) (34mins)



Practice what you've learnt using this interactive roleplay:

- [Clarifying the customer value proposition](#)

03 Business Model Thinking

Why is Business Model Thinking essential for sustainable growth?

Harvard Business Publishing calls business model thinking one of the **“three critical business acumen skills leaders need now”**. It’s the ability to understand how a business creates, delivers, and captures value—and how to adapt that model in a changing environment.

Professionals who think in business models can:

- Connect strategy, operations, and financial outcomes
- Spot opportunities for innovation and efficiency
- Adapt models to shifting market conditions
- Align teams around shared business goals



Build this hot skill with these courses:

- [Systems Thinking](#) (34mins)
- [Critical Thinking and Problem Solving](#) (34mins)
- [Aligning Team and Organizational Goals as a Business Leader](#) (43mins)



Practice what you’ve learnt using this interactive roleplay:

- [Business model thinking for growth](#)

04 Negotiation and Deal Making

Why are Negotiation & Deal-Making vital to commercial acumen?

The Program on Negotiation at Harvard Law School defines deal-making as “a strategic endeavor that shapes relationships and drives profitability”. It’s not just about closing deals—**it’s about creating value, building trust, and navigating complexity with confidence.**

Professionals skilled in negotiation & deal-making can:

- Create win-win outcomes through strategic dialogue
- Navigate complex stakeholder dynamics
- Balance assertiveness with empathy
- Drive profitable, sustainable agreements



Build this hot skill with these courses:

- [Strategic Negotiation](#) (56mins)
- [Mindsets and Strategies for Negotiation Success](#) (27mins)
- [Strategies for Negotiation Nano Tips with Chris Croft](#) (8mins 41s)



Practice what you’ve learnt using these interactive roleplays:

- [Structuring a deal in a negotiation](#)
- [Negotiating a contract with a long-term partner](#)
- [Address Last Minute Concerns Before Closing a Deal](#)